

A. The Indian position is that our conscience is clear and as a nation we don't do anything nefarious and that's why if you want to mention Balochistan, do it by all means. It is an open book as far as India is concerned as we have nothing to hide.

Q. Coming to the visit of US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton, what's the reason she had so many engagements in Mumbai and Delhi as compared to the time spent talking bilateral issues with you?

A. Perhaps Clinton wanted to disabuse the kind

of impression that was gaining ground in India that the Barack Obama administration was lukewarm towards India. I think right throughout her visit, her pronouncements have all been very positive towards India. Then in our bilateral talks, she sounded positive, sounded decisive at times. So we feel that we can continue to depend on the Obama administration. And the fact that Manmohan Singh has been bestowed the honour of being the first visiting statesman to the White House in November is further indication of the fact that contrary to the whispers we hear, we are on the right note with the United States.

Q. There were some concerns about the recent G8 proposal to restrict sales of nuclear enrichment and reprocessing technology to non-signatories of NPT including India. Will this alter America's approach while dealing with India?

A. No. On India's civil nuclear treaty with the US, Clinton said they are very serious and will continue to make headway according to the agreement. Nothing is going to change.

Q. Finally, there seems to be a sense of drift in India's foreign policy whether in relations with Pakistan or the United States or other countries.

A. I disagree. There is a thread of continuity in India's foreign policy. Our response or degree of emphasis may vary from time to time but the thread is visible. There is absolutely no drift or ambivalence.

repeated intrusions by its army all across the Line of Actual Control. India's response has been muted. When Manmohan went to Arunachal Pradesh, he deferred visiting Tawang. Last month, when the Indian Air Force wanted to hold a ceremony to mark the deployment of its new fleet of Sukhoi fighters at Tezpur, South Block advised them to keep it low key lest it provoke China. India's effort to develop the North-east has been flagging in contrast to China's decisive thrust to develop infrastructure connecting Tibet and Beijing. Chinese influence in the North-east has grown, with illegal trade in Chinese goods booming.

Nor has India learnt to take a leaf from China's tremendous success in international trade. To ensure energy security and a market for its goods, China has moved aggressively to woo African countries. Chinese President Hu Jintao and Premier Wen Jiabao make it a point to visit Africa regularly while Manmohan's visits have been less frequent and mainly to larger nations such as South Africa and Nigeria. As a measure of its clout in the continent, when China hosted a summit in 2006, almost 40 African leaders turned up. Last year when India held a similar summit, only 10 leaders attended. This after India extended close to \$1 billion as credit to various African countries and also in the past helped many of them gain freedom.

In ASEAN, which China dominates, India had long neglected the region and only in the 1990s launched its "Look East" policy. But it has struggled for the past four years to hammer out a Free Trade Agreement with ASEAN countries, resulting in loss of time and opportunity. Even with Russia, its old friend, trade has been stagnant. With Moscow demanding an additional \$2 billion to build the Gorshkov aircraft carrier, relations have been strained.

India's Middle East policy is in no better shape. While it has taken strides in its ties with Israel—Tel Aviv is now India's largest defence seller—relations with most Arab nations have stagnated. Even then Manmohan waited for the fag end of his first term to visit Oman and Qatar. A trip to Saudi Arabia, which has recently shown keenness to engage India, is yet to materialise. As Kanwal Sibal, a former foreign secretary, says: "We don't show much of our flag either in Africa or the Middle East." On the Palestinian issue, India is rarely consulted and in Iraq its role is even more marginal.

On Iran, while it correctly opposes Tehran's



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